

ANI

Takeaways

- **Ashokan emblem on a plaque at the renovated Hazratbal sets off protests**
- **NCP, PDP, Mirwaiz et al decry the installation, calling it blasphemy**
- **BJP chairperson of Waqf Board calls for harsh action**

Sajad Lone called it unfortunate.

On her part, BJP leader Darakshan Andrabi, who had steered the renovation as the Waqf chairperson since 2022, erupted in fury. Referring to the perpetrators as terrorists, she called for the full weight of the Public Safety Act (PSA) to be brought down on them. "I've tolerated venom for three years from those who call themselves elected representatives. Their hooliganism went on for 35 years. They fed militants in their homes, and it's they who did this," Andrabi told the press, in a none-too-veiled barb at the NC. This was not organic popular emotion but a well-planned political conspiracy, she fumed.

THE WAQF TAKEOVER

For decades, Hazratbal had been a symbolic power centre of the NC; the Sheikh used it as a personal pulpit, his son Farooq and now Omar visit on special Islamic days. But in recent years, the landscape has changed in Kashmir. The J&K Reorganisation Act, 2019, repealed the Muslim Specified Waqf Board Act, 2005, streamlining it with the central Waqf Act, which saw a controversial amendment in 2025. With it, the new BJP-led board has tightened its grip around Kashmir's 32,000-plus religious properties, assuming sweeping control over their affairs.

The Omar government's ascension has led to persistent attempts to change that, but so far in vain. The Centre seems reluctant to let go—analysts put that down to a need to choke spaces for the separatist narrative. The huge financial donations and rent fees from religious places are not an immaterial factor either: in August 2022, the board vacated donation boxes out of J&K's shrines, ending the traditional practice of endowments to *sajada nisheens* and *mutawallis*. Three years later, that dual spiritual-temporal power is seeing a renewed war. ■

AJIT PAWAR'S NCP SWIMS with the Mahayuti, but with a presumed teflon coating: it kept a distinct aloofness from the majoritarianism of its senior ally, the BJP. But this complex game is now threatening to jeopardise its social and political base. Chafing at the nub of this perceived incongruence was a photo tweeted lately by the BJP's star MP Kangana Ranaut: it showed Ajit's wife Sunetra Pawar, a Rajya Sabha MP, attending a meeting of the Rashtra Sevika Samiti, the RSS women's wing.

The flutter it caused in Maharashtra was to be expected. Rohit Pawar, Ajit's nephew and an MLA of the rival NCP(SCP), promptly accused his uncle of "double standards", for claiming to be of "progressive" stock while consorting with the saffron brotherhood. They were under pressure to capitulate fully, Rohit added for good measure. Sources even say the recent controversy over Ajit's talking down to a lady IPS officer in an illegal sand mining case in Solapur—caught in a viral video—is being fanned by the BJP to corner him.

Sunetra claims her presence at the meeting, hosted by Ranaut, was apolitical. Ajit, too, insists his NCP is wedded to a Maharashtrian credo deriving from Shivaji, Phule and Ambedkar, and would "never compromise". The NCP's base is non-Brahmin, especially Maratha. The RSS ecosystem is seen as aligned to a Brahminical ethos. Despite the alliance with the BJP since 2023, Ajit and his men have refrained from visiting the RSS headquarters at Nagpur, unlike other Mahayuti figures.

SECULAR GUARANTOR

The NCP also enjoys support from a section of Muslims, so communal riots at places like Yavat in Pune have led to unease in its ranks. Aggravating it were incendiary speeches by BJP leaders